



In *Declaration of Independence*, by John Trumbull, the drafting committee is shown presenting its work to Congress. Thomas Jefferson can be seen standing fourth from the left.

hard to overstate the importance of the Declaration of Independence. It made, for the time, an astonishing claim: “that all men are created equal.” It further claimed “that governments are instituted among men deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed.”

These were actively seditious sentiments that neither George III of England nor Louis XVI of France could have any sympathy with. They nonetheless formed the bedrock of what would become the United States and, indeed, liberal political systems across the Western world. These political creeds, derived from the work of British and French Enlightenment thinkers, led to the creation of the first modern state and, in doing so, changed the world.

The destiny of America

Jefferson remains an enigma. He loathed monarchy yet loved pre-Revolutionary

France, where he was the United States’ first ambassador, delighting in its civilized elegance. He claimed to despise high office yet served two terms as President of the United States. And, as president, in 1803 he drove through the Louisiana Purchase, which saw a vast area west of the Mississippi transferred at a bargain price from France, its nominal ruler, to the United States. He understood that the destiny of the US lay in its colonization of the vast lands to the west, he assented to the notion that its indigenous inhabitants should be driven off, and he held enslaved people. “Blacks,” he asserted, “are inferior to the whites in the endowments both of body and mind.” Whereas Washington, also a patrician Virginian, freed his enslaved people, Jefferson opted not to.

None of this, though, can diminish Jefferson’s significance in articulating notions of liberty that resonate today. And even though he felt slavery was wrong, his personal belief was that emancipation would be bad for both enslaved and white Americans—unless they were returned to Africa.